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ARTICLE

There Is No Off Switch: How Surveillance Followed Us Home





BY PNW STAFF SEPTEMBER 09, 2026

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The television is off. The screen is dark. The family has stopped watching.

But what if the television has not stopped watching them?

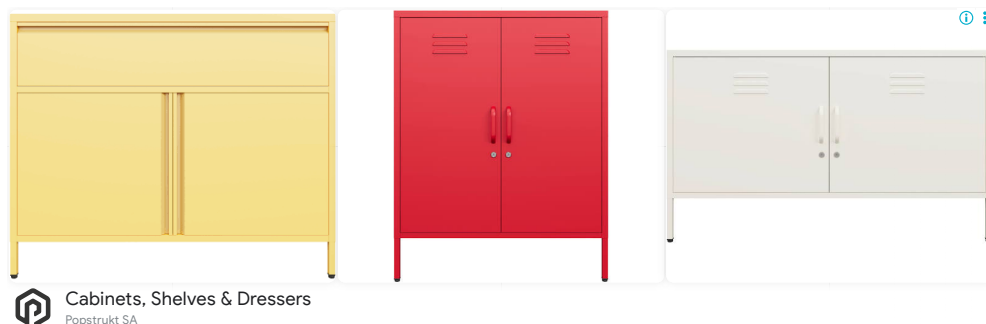
A major investigation into LG smart televisions has uncovered an extraordinary amount of data collection occurring through a device millions of families still think of as little more than an entertainment system. Researchers working with Gamers Nexus, Level1Techs and independent security specialists found televisions scanning local networks and identifying nearby phones, smartwatches, printers, thermostats, air purifiers and other connected devices.

They also examined LG's Automatic Content Recognition technology, which can identify what viewers are watching across apps and external inputs, including content delivered through HDMI. Voice commands could be converted into text and stored in logs, while researchers reported that microphone activity sometimes continued for approximately 10 to 15 seconds after a user stopped speaking. In some tests, voice data was stored while the television was disconnected from the internet and transmitted after connectivity returned.

The potential scale is enormous. LG Ad Solutions says its global footprint encompasses approximately 216 million LG smart televisions.

Researchers also uncovered security vulnerabilities that they believe could potentially allow a compromised television to become a covert listening device.

That is troubling enough. But the most disturbing part of the investigation is not what one television may know. It is how perfectly that television fits into a much larger surveillance system already surrounding us.



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The Tracking Device In Your Pocket

Your phone knows where you sleep, where you work, which church you at  which medical offices you visit and whose home you entered last night.

Apps can collect location information, browsing activity, device identifiers, purchases and behavioral data--often through software quietly embedded inside otherwise ordinary applications.

A federal judge recently allowed a lawsuit against Allstate to proceed over allegations that its analytics subsidiary tracked drivers through their phones. The lawsuit claims software incorporated into apps such as GasBuddy, Life360 and Fuel Rewards collected information about location, trip distance, speed, braking and phone usage. That information was allegedly used to influence insurance decisions or sold to other insurers. Allstate denies improperly collecting the data and says users consented.

But this illustrates how little control people may have over information produced by devices they carry everywhere. Someone can download an app to find cheaper gasoline without realizing that a separate company may be learning how fast he drives, how hard he brakes and where he travels.

The smartphone did not merely give us access to the world. It gave the world access to us.



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Your Car Is Taking Notes

Modern automobiles have become computers on wheels, equipped with cameras, microphones, GPS systems, internet connections and sensors capable of recording enormous amounts of information.

General Motors reached settlements after regulators alleged that precise vehicle locations and driving behavior--including speeding, hard braking and nighttime driving--were collected and shared with consumer-reporting agencies without adequate consent. Insurers could then use those reports when determining rates or coverage. In 2026, GM agreed to pay \$12.75 million to resolve a California investigation into its handling and sale of driver data.

Then there are the cameras watching from outside the vehicle.

Flock Safety reportedly operates approximately 120,000 AI-powered license-plate readers across 49 states. These cameras can help police locate stolen vehicles and solve serious crimes, but they can also create searchable records of where innocent people travel. Florida recently banned local police from using the cameras on state highways, while Texas paused some funding as concern grows over who can access the data and how it may be used.

Your phone knows where you are going. Your car knows how you drove there. Roadside cameras know when you passed. Your doorbell camera knows when you returned.

Every Device Knows A Piece Of You

The television recognizes what you watch. The smartwatch records your movement and sleep. The thermostat learns when you are home. The digital assistant waits for your voice. The security system monitors visitors. Store loyalty programs record what you purchase, while websites follow what you search and read.

No single device needs to know everything. Each one knows a piece.

That is what makes this new era different. In the past, records were often scattered across incompatible databases and difficult to analyze. Artificial intelligence can now search enormous collections of information, recognize patterns and connect fragments that once appeared unrelated.

Viewing habits, locations, purchases, relationships, health information, religious interests and political activity can be assembled into something resembling a digital dossier. Once collected, that information can be sold, copied, hacked, subpoenaed or repurposed. Data gathered today for advertising could be used tomorrow for insurance, financial access, employment screening or government investigation.

We are repeatedly told that we consented. Somewhere inside pages of legal language, we clicked "agree." But consent that requires surrendering privacy to use a television, telephone or automobile is rapidly becoming no choice at all.

A System The World Once Could Not Imagine

The surveillance system did not arrive at our doors wearing a uniform. It arrived as a television offering personalized recommendations, a phone promising convenience, a car designed to keep us connected and a camera claiming to keep our neighborhoods safe. We welcomed each device separately, rarely noticing the system they were creating together.

The question is no longer whether someone is watching. The question is who possesses the information, what they intend to do with it--and whether we will still have the power to say no when all those separate eyes finally become one.

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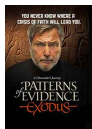
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